Leadership Tool: Eight Best Practices for Leading Friends

Managing individuals who were once peers or friends can present unique challenges for leaders. The workplace is a space where many people form deep, lasting relationships due to the sheer number of hours spent working alongside one another. Over a 40-year career, this equates to nearly 90,000 hours with colleagues, making it inevitable that some professional relationships will evolve into friendships (Laker et al., 2020). Research indicates that having friends at work boosts job satisfaction and productivity (Patel et al., 2023). However, when one friend is promoted to a leadership position, the dynamic shifts, and navigating the boss-friend relationship can become challenging. Leaders who are now managing former friends must learn how to balance maintaining the friendship while fulfilling their professional obligations.

Best Practice #1: Acknowledge the Power Shift

One of the most critical steps for leaders managing friends is to acknowledge the shift in power dynamics. A promotion changes the balance from a relationship of equality to one of meritocracy. However, many first-time managers fail to address this shift, assuming this initial feeling of discomfort will naturally dissipate. This leads to newly promoted managers not directly addressing changes in their friendships after their promotion, which can later lead to feelings of regret. Denying the change can place unnecessary strain on the relationship and hinder effective leadership. To maintain both the professional relationship and the friendship, it's essential to initiate an open dialogue with friends, acknowledging that the dynamic has changed and setting expectations for both the personal and professional aspects of the relationship.

Clear communication about the shift in roles can help avoid misunderstandings. Leaders can frame these conversations around the value they place on the friendship while being honest about the new boundaries needed in their professional roles. The goal is to preserve the relationship without allowing it to compromise fairness and objectivity in the workplace. By addressing the elephant in the room, leaders can maintain transparency and mutual respect, which is critical in both friendships and professional settings.

Best Practice #2: Accept Your New Role and Responsibilities

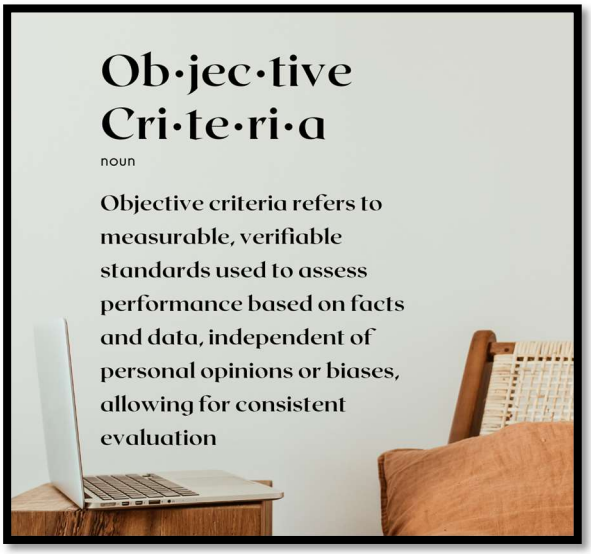
Transitioning from being a peer to being the leader requires a shift in behavior. While it can be tempting to maintain the same level of casual interaction that existed before the promotion, it's

important for new leaders to recognize that their behavior now sets the tone for the entire team. One common mistake is to revert to “friend mode,” particularly in stressful situations, which can lead to gossip or sharing confidential information. Leaders must be mindful of their new responsibilities and avoid engaging in conversations that could undermine their authority or cause division within the team.

Instead, leaders should seek out mentors, coaches, or peers at their own level to confide in and offload work-related frustrations. These individuals can offer guidance and support while ensuring that sensitive information remains confidential. By modeling professional behavior, leaders set a standard for the entire team and foster an environment of trust. Additionally, maintaining a safe distance from social media interactions with direct reports can help establish clear boundaries and prevent oversharing, which can blur the lines between professional and personal relationships.

Best Practice #3: Consistency and Fairness

As a leader, it’s crucial to treat all team members with consistency and fairness, regardless of personal relationships. While it’s natural to be closer to certain individuals, especially friends, leaders must be careful not to show favoritism. If team members sense that one person is receiving preferential treatment, it can lead to resentment and toxic workplace behavior. To avoid this, leaders should strive to include the entire team in social interactions, such as extending lunch invitations to everyone, not just friends.



One of the best ways to ensure fairness is to implement clear evaluation systems based on objective criteria. Tools such as Objectives and Key Results (OKRs) can provide a standardized way to measure performance, ensuring that all team members are held to the same standards. By relying on data-driven assessments rather than personal feelings, leaders can make decisions that are both fair and transparent, reducing the risk of bias. This consistency is key to maintaining trust and respect among the team.

Best Practice #4: Set Boundaries Early

Establishing boundaries early is crucial for leaders who are transitioning from a peer to a managerial role. Clear boundaries help prevent confusion about the evolving dynamics of the relationship and ensure that both parties understand their new roles. Without these boundaries, the friendship can interfere with the leader’s ability to be objective and fair in their professional responsibilities. Early in the transition, leaders should initiate a candid conversation with their

friends to acknowledge the changes in their relationship and set expectations for how to balance their personal and professional lives.

Setting boundaries also allows leaders to maintain authority and respect within the team. By defining the limits of personal and professional interactions, leaders can ensure that their friendships do not lead to perceptions of favoritism or bias. For example, maintaining discretion about personal matters at work and avoiding preferential treatment in assignments or evaluations are key aspects of setting and maintaining boundaries. This proactive approach ensures that both the friendship and the working relationship are preserved in a healthy and productive way.

Best Practice #5: Make Tough Decisions Without Letting Emotions Get in the Way

Being in a leadership role means making tough decisions that may not always be well-received, especially when friends are involved. It's essential for leaders to accept that not everyone will like them, and that's okay. Leaders are tasked with making decisions in the best interest of the organization, and that may sometimes mean making choices that could negatively affect their friends. Navigating friendships as a leader requires a high level of emotional intelligence. Leaders must be aware of their own emotions and the emotions of others, responding with compassion while maintaining professional boundaries. Former peers may react negatively to decisions, showing anger, resentment, or passive-aggressiveness.

It's important for leaders to remain calm and focused, not allowing these emotional responses to influence their leadership. By maintaining a compassionate yet firm approach, leaders can help their friends and colleagues understand that the decisions they make are in the best interest of the organization. At the same time, leaders should recognize their own emotions and not shy away from seeking support when needed. Whether through mentorship, peer support, or professional coaching, having a trusted confidant can help leaders manage the emotional complexities of their role without compromising their relationships or their professional responsibilities.

Best Practice #6: Manage Social Media Connections and Personal Interactions

In today's hyper-connected world, social media adds an additional layer of complexity to the boss-friend dynamic. Many leaders and employees are connected on various social media platforms, where the lines between personal and professional lives can become blurred. This can lead to uncomfortable situations, as friends may inadvertently flaunt their relationship with the leader in ways that make others feel excluded or less valued. It's essential for leaders to be mindful of how much they share on social media and to avoid posting anything that could be perceived as favoritism or unprofessional. Information shared outside of work should be kept as private as possible to prevent any misunderstandings or damage to the leader's credibility. Leaders should remember that their behavior, both online and offline, sets an example for the entire team, and oversharing can undermine the boundaries they have worked to establish.

Best Practice #7: Avoid Gossip

Leaders must exercise caution when it comes to engaging in gossip, especially with colleagues or friends within the workplace. Gossiping undermines a leader's authority and can quickly erode the trust they have built with their team. As a leader, you are no longer just a peer, but someone responsible for setting the tone and maintaining a professional environment. When leaders engage in gossip, it creates a toxic work atmosphere, encouraging negativity and division among team members.

Avoiding gossip is also about modeling appropriate behavior. By steering clear of conversations that tear others down or share unnecessary information, leaders demonstrate that they prioritize professionalism and fairness. It's important for leaders to know when to walk away from unproductive discussions and redirect conversations toward productive outcomes. Instead of gossiping, they should aim to create an open, solution-oriented dialogue with the team that fosters trust and transparency. This approach helps to build a positive culture where employees feel supported and respected.

Conclusion

Ultimately, the awkwardness of managing friends will fade over time as both the leader and their friends adjust to the new dynamic. As leaders continue to grow in their roles, they will encounter new challenges, but the lessons learned from managing friends will provide a strong foundation for handling difficult conversations, making tough decisions, and fostering a positive team culture. By leading with integrity, fairness, and transparency, leaders can navigate the complexities of workplace friendships while maintaining both strong relationships and effective teams.

Leading friends in the workplace requires a delicate balance of professionalism, emotional intelligence, and transparency. While managing former peers can initially create awkwardness and challenges, leaders who acknowledge the shift in power dynamics, set clear boundaries, and maintain fairness can successfully navigate these complex relationships. By avoiding gossip, making objective decisions, and finding appropriate confidants, leaders preserve their authority while fostering a supportive and productive work environment.

References:

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